enemies. He was told to write to his brother Dost Mohammad and order him to surrender. When he refused, saying he was a poor blind captive and without influence, his tormentors closed in. One – Atta Mohammad, the nobleman who had imprisoned Shuja and threatened to drown him in the Indus, and whose father Fatteh Khan had accused of plotting rebellion and had executed – hacked off his ear, naming his grievance as he did so. A second hacked off the other, voicing another complaint; a third the nose. One hand was cut off, then the other. As the blood haemorrhaged out, each of the nobles named the slight done to him for which he was now claiming vengeance, 'thus depriving Fatteh Khan of the highest consolation the mind of a man can possess under torment – a conscience void of offence'. The Wazir bore the torture without complaint, until, when his beard was cut off, he burst into tears. When both feet had been hacked off, Atta Mohammad finally cut Fatteh Khan's throat.[32]

As before, with Shah Zaman's murder of Fatteh's father Payindah Khan, it was one thing to kill the chief of the Barakzais, but quite another to round up the clan. Several of the brothers managed to escape from the garden party and fought their way out of Herat. Two others who were still luxuriating in a hamam 'heard what had happened, quickly ran from the steam room, and fled. They laid hands on two horses belonging to merchants in the covered bazaar, and rode off towards Kandahar. At the fortress of Nad Ali, they joined the Wazir's mother and resolved to avenge their brother's execution.'[33] Fatteh Khan may have been killed, but the rest of the clan now declared war on Shah Mahmoud and Prince Kamran and began to encourage rebellion across their dominions.

As the revolt spread, invitations from tribal elders began to arrive in Ludhiana for Shah Shuja, encouraging him to reclaim his throne and restore order. This was the moment Shuja had been waiting for. With Wa'fa Begum's assistance, he managed to procure weapons and recruit a ragtag assortment of soldiers of fortune, including the American mercenary 'General' Josiah Harlan. Though shadowed all the way by a British intelligence officer, Captain Ross, and his two assistants, all of them disguised as Gurkhas, he made his way to the Sindhi banking centre of Shikarpur.[34] There he secured a loan from the Hindu money-lenders.[h] He quickly raised a body of troops, then marched northwards and within weeks had managed to recapture his old base of Peshawar.